

The attic adventure and the secret of Lindenwood

Hidden treasure story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Attic Discovery

It began on a rainy Saturday afternoon. Sam Carter, an adventurous eleven-year-old with a mop of brown curls and eyes that always seemed to sparkle with mischief, stood staring at the rain snaking down his bedroom window. He flopped onto his bed, bored and restless. Sam's parents were downstairs, busy organizing old boxes for their upcoming move to a new house across town.

"Sam! Want to help us in the attic?" his dad called up the stairs.

Sam considered the offer. The attic was dusty, dark, and filled with forgotten things. It was also, he thought suddenly, a place where mysteries might still be hiding.

He bounded up the creaking staircase, careful not to slip. The attic was chilly, and sunlight peeked through the small round window, lighting up motes of dust that danced in the air. Sam's parents were already deep into old boxes, surrounded by faded photo albums, broken lamps, and squeaky toys from when he was much younger.

"Here, take this box of books and see if there's anything you want to keep," his mom said, handing him a heavy cardboard box.

Sam knelt down and started rummaging through the pile. Most books were boring: math workbooks, fairy tales for small children, and his dad's old school textbooks. But then, at the bottom, something caught his eye—a battered leather-bound notebook with a faded compass embossed on the cover.

He opened it carefully. The pages were yellowed, and the writing, done in looping green ink, seemed ancient. Maps, sketches of strange locations, and peculiar riddles filled the pages. Sam's heart thudded in his chest.

“What’s that you’ve got, Sam?” his dad asked.

“I think it’s a travel journal,” Sam replied, his voice trembling with excitement. “But look—these are clues! Maybe even a treasure map!”

His parents smiled at his enthusiasm and told him to keep it if he wanted. Sam, notebook firmly in hand, raced down to his room. He had no idea that with this single discovery, his life was about to become the adventure he’d always dreamed of.

Chapter 2: The First Riddle

Sam spread the journal across his desk and examined the first page more closely. There was a hand-drawn map of his own town—Lindenwood—and some strange notations. Next to the map, a riddle was scrawled:

“In shadow’s grasp where secrets sleep,

The oldest oak, its roots run deep.

Beneath its arms, a symbol lies—

A key to wonders, truth, and prize.”

Sam’s mind raced. He knew Lindenwood Park was famous for its ancient oak tree. Could that be the one? His heart skipped with excitement—and a little bit of fear. It was already late afternoon and the rain hadn’t stopped. But the thought of adventure overpowered his worries.

He tugged on his raincoat, grabbed his flashlight, and stuffed the journal into his backpack. As he was about to sneak out, his little sister, Emily, spotted him.

“Where are you going? Can I come?” she pleaded, clutching her stuffed bunny.

Sam hesitated. Emily was only seven, easily scared—and often a tattletale. But her wide, hopeful eyes softened him.

“Alright, but you have to promise not to tell Mom and Dad,” he whispered.

Emily grinned and zipped up her own raincoat, hopping after him like an excited puppy.

They sloshed through puddles as they hurried to the park. Dark clouds lingered overhead, but the rain had slowed to a drizzle. Sam led Emily beneath the twisted, gnarled branches of the great oak, its roots coiling out of the earth like giant snakes.

He knelt at the base of the trunk and brushed aside damp leaves, searching for anything unusual. Emily helped, poking her fingers into the soft earth.

“Look, Sam!” she shouted suddenly, pointing to a knot in the trunk. Inside was a strange marking—a spiral carved into the wood.

“That must be the symbol!” Sam declared. He opened the journal, comparing the spiral to a sketch on the next page. It matched perfectly.

Beside the sketch was a new riddle:

“From the green giant’s swirling mark,

Count seven paces to the lark.

Where feathered singers gather round,

The next clue’s waiting underground.”

Sam gazed across the park, searching for somewhere birds gathered. Near the playground, a cluster of bushes was filled with chirping sparrows.

“Let’s try over there,” he said.

Carefully, Sam counted seven paces from the oak toward the bushes. He knelt and dug through the muddy ground, his hands trembling with anticipation. Suddenly, his fingers brushed against something hard—an old glass jar, sealed tight and containing a rolled-up piece of paper.

Sam’s pulse thundered. He and Emily shared a wide-eyed look. The adventure had truly begun.

Chapter 3: The Forgotten Library

Back at home, they carefully unrolled the fragile piece of paper. It held another poem, hinting at the next location:

“Wise words slumber where dust coats the air,

Behind the lion’s gaze, the next clue is there.

Seek the silent guardian with golden mane,

Your journey continues beyond the mundane.”

Sam instantly thought of the Lindenwood Library. In the reading room, a stone lion statue guarded a row of ancient, rarely touched books. The library was about to close for the day, but Sam convinced his parents that he and Emily needed to return some books before dinner.

They hurried to the library, hearts still pounding from their earlier discovery. The building’s stone walls stood solemnly in the dimming light, and inside, the scent of old paper and wood polish greeted them.

Sam led Emily to the reading room. The stone lion, majestic and proud, stood

among the shadows. The children searched around its base, running their hands over the cold marble.

“Maybe it’s hidden in the books behind the lion,” Emily suggested.

Sam nodded and scanned the spines. One book, “The Golden Myths of Lindenwood,” looked more worn than the others. He pulled it gently from the shelf. A folded card fluttered out and landed at his feet.

On the card was a new riddle:

“Past rivers and rails, where the wildflowers sway,

A forgotten bridge in the light of day.

Below its bones, where time forgets,

A puzzle of stones your hands must set.”

Sam grinned. There was an old railway bridge by the edge of town, surrounded by wildflowers. It had been abandoned for years.

Emily looked nervous. “What if it’s dangerous?”

“We’ll be careful,” Sam said confidently, though he felt a shiver of nervousness himself.

They left the library just as the sun dipped behind the clouds, golden light stretching over Lindenwood. Sam felt stronger with every clue they solved—like the riddles were leading him to something greater than just a treasure.

Chapter 4: The Bridge of Bones

The abandoned railway bridge loomed ahead, its rusted skeleton stretching over a shallow creek. Wildflowers and tall grass swayed in the evening breeze. The place felt both beautiful and eerie, as if it held memories of all the trains and travelers that had once passed this way.

Sam and Emily carefully climbed down the embankment beneath the bridge. The ground was muddy, and water trickled softly nearby. Under the bridge, the world smelled of earth and old wood.

Sam knelt and examined the underside of the bridge. The journal's next page showed a crude drawing: a pattern of flat stones arranged in a circle. He searched for similar stones nearby and soon found a pile, half-buried under weeds.

"Help me arrange them," Sam whispered.

They worked together, setting the stones into a circle as shown in the drawing. When the last stone was placed, there was a faint click. A small, hidden compartment slid open in the bridge's foundation, revealing a tin box.

With trembling hands, Sam opened it. Inside was a metal key and another note:

"Return to the place where stories are born,

Where voices echo in twilight and morn.

Unlock the hidden, the old and the wise—

There lies the truth and the final prize."

Sam looked at the key. It was old, ornate, and heavy in his palm.

"Back to the library?" Emily guessed.

Sam nodded. But this time, he was sure they weren't looking for books—they

were looking for something hidden, something no one else had found in a long, long time.

Chapter 5: Secrets in the Stacks

The next morning, they set out early for the library, the key burning a hole in Sam's pocket. The building was nearly empty, just the way Sam liked it for exploring.

They roamed the aisles, searching for anything that looked like it could be unlocked. In a back corner, Sam noticed a dusty old door he'd never seen before. On the door was a strange lock, shaped just like the key they'd found.

Sam's hands shook as he slid the key into the lock and turned it. The door creaked open, revealing a narrow spiral staircase leading downward, into the unknown.

"Are you sure we should go?" Emily whispered.

"We've come this far," Sam replied, his voice steady even though his heart hammered in his chest. "We have to see what's down there."

They descended into the darkness, using their flashlights to guide the way. The air grew cooler, thick with the smell of old paper and stone. At the bottom, they found themselves in a hidden storeroom, filled with ancient manuscripts, dusty artifacts, and strange objects from the past.

In the center of the room stood a pedestal, and on it, a wooden box covered in symbols matching those in the journal. Sam opened the journal to the last page. There was a final riddle—and a warning:

"Three trials await, of courage, wit, and heart,

Each must be conquered before you can part

With the prize you seek, the secret untold—

Only the brave may the treasure behold.”

Sam swallowed. “Three trials,” he said. “I guess we have to solve them to get the treasure.”

Emily squeezed his hand. “We can do it. We’re a team.”

Chapter 6: The Three Trials

The first trial began as soon as they touched the box. The walls seemed to ripple, and suddenly, they found themselves in a room filled with mirrors. Each mirror reflected not just their faces, but their fears—Sam saw himself lost and alone, Emily saw herself in the dark.

A disembodied voice echoed: “Face your fears and find the door.”

Sam closed his eyes and took a deep breath. He remembered the courage he had felt solving each riddle, the determination he had found with every clue. He reached for Emily’s hand.

“Let’s walk forward together,” he said.

They marched hand in hand toward the mirror that frightened them the most. As they drew near, the glass shimmered, and then melted away, revealing a passage forward.

The second trial was a puzzle. In the next chamber, a giant stone tablet showed a jumble of letters and symbols. The voice whispered again: “Only the wise shall find the way.”

Sam and Emily worked together, using clues from the journal and their own cleverness to unscramble the puzzle. It took patience and teamwork, but eventually, they solved it—a hidden compartment opened to reveal the way onward.

The final trial was one of heart. In the last chamber, a simple question was inscribed on the wall: “What is the greatest treasure?”

Sam thought of gold, jewels, riches—but then he looked at Emily, and remembered the laughter, the teamwork, and the adventure they had shared.

Sam stepped forward. “The greatest treasure is friendship—and family,” he said.

The room glowed with a warm golden light. The wooden box opened on the pedestal, revealing a collection of old coins, a beautiful compass, and a letter.

Chapter 7: The True Treasure

Sam and Emily gathered around the box, eyes wide in wonder. The coins glittered in the dim light, and the compass spun gently, pointing not north, but toward each of them in turn.

Sam picked up the letter and read aloud:

“To the brave and clever souls who found this place:

True treasure is not measured in gold or gems,

But in the journey, the riddles solved,

The courage to face the unknown,

And the friendship that grows along the way.

If you hold this letter, you have found what truly matters most.

Wear this compass, and let your heart be your guide.”

Sam closed the letter, understanding at last. The adventure had brought him closer to his sister, taught him to be brave, and shown him the magic in the world around him.

As they climbed back up the spiral staircase, Sam knew he would never forget this journey. The attic, the oak tree, the library, the bridge, the secret room—all were part of a story that would stay with him forever.

When they emerged into the bright afternoon, their parents greeted them with puzzled smiles.

“Find anything interesting?” their mom asked.

Sam grinned and held up the compass. “The most amazing treasure of all.”

Emily giggled, tucking her arm through his. Together, they walked home, their hearts lighter and their minds swirling with dreams of the next great adventure waiting just beyond the horizon.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What was the first item Sam discovered in the attic?

- An old photograph
- A dusty book
- A leather-bound notebook
- A broken toy

2) What did the first riddle refer to?

- A hidden treasure under the sea
- The oldest oak tree in Lindenwood
- A secret passage in the library
- A forgotten bridge in the woods

3) What did Sam and Emily find at the base of the oak tree?

- A treasure chest
- A spiral marking
- A map of the park
- A hidden door

4) What did the key they found unlock?

- A door to a secret library
- A hidden treasure chest
- A trapdoor in the attic
- A hidden storeroom in the library

5) What was the first trial Sam and Emily faced in the hidden storeroom?

- A riddle
- A mirror maze
- A physical challenge
- A guessing game

6) What did Sam say was the greatest treasure at the end of their adventure?

- Gold coins
- A magical compass
- Friendship and family
- The journal with riddles

Correct answers:

1) A leather-bound notebook 2) The oldest oak tree in Lindenwood 3) A spiral marking 4) A hidden storeroom in the library 5) A mirror maze 6) Friendship and family

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Mop: A tool for cleaning floors, typically made of a long handle and a bundle of soft strings or cloth at the end.

Ancient: Very old; from a time long ago.

Ornate: Very decorated, often with complex patterns or designs.

Compartment: A separate section or part of something, often used for storage.

Disembodied: Not having a physical body; the voice or presence that seems to come from nowhere.

Puzzle: A game or problem that requires thought and skill to solve.